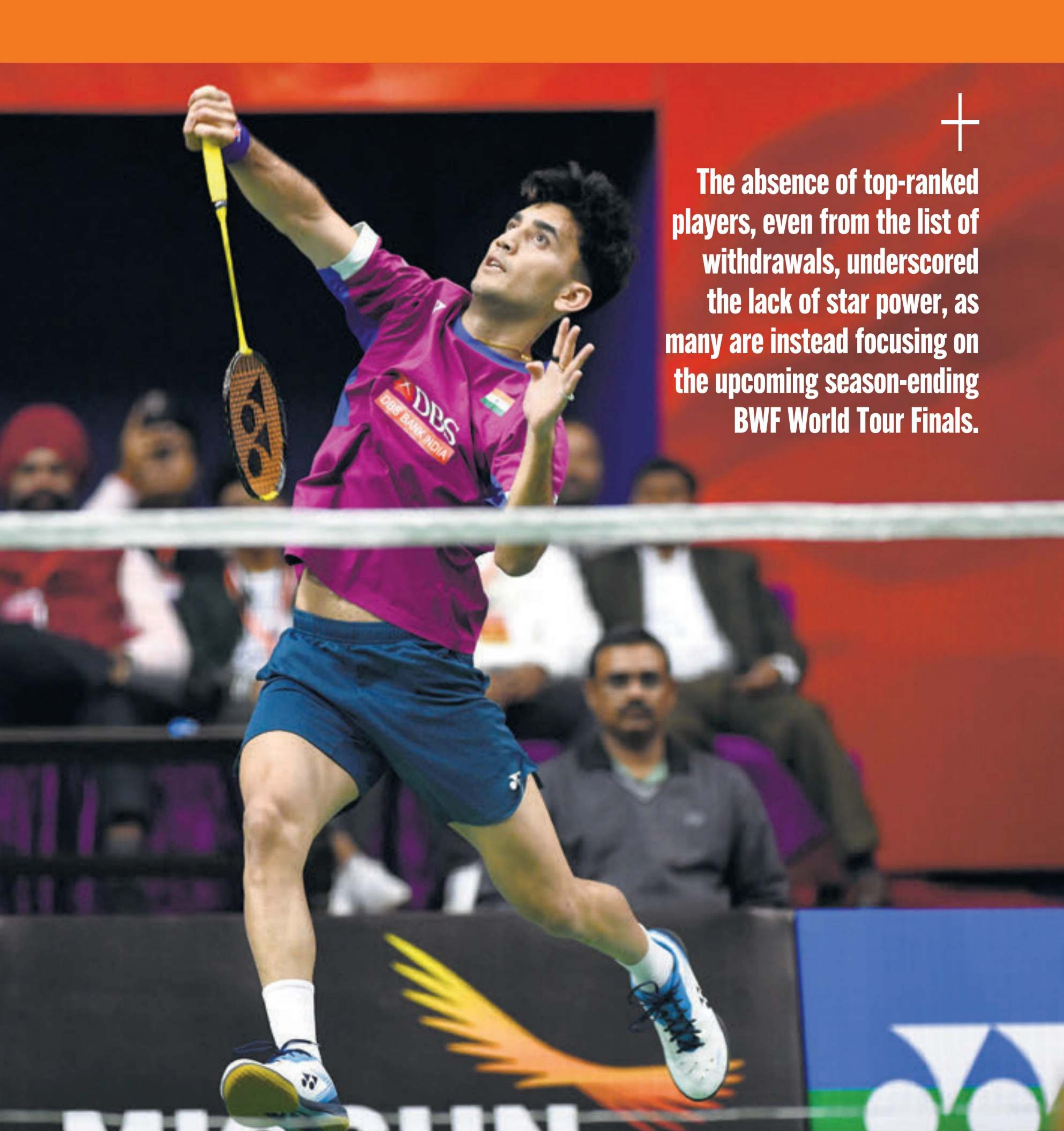




The absence of top-ranked players, even from the list of withdrawals, underscored the lack of star power, as many are instead focusing on the upcoming season-ending BWF World Tour Finals.

Nozomi Okuhara in the women's category, had a significantly weaker field this year. Across all sections of the draw, Indian players dominated, with foreign participation largely limited to those chasing crucial ranking points ahead of year-end. The absence of top-ranked players, even from the list of withdrawals,

underscored the lack of star power, as many are instead focusing on the upcoming season-ending BWF World Tour Finals.

Consider this: Five of the top eight seeds in both singles draws were Indians, including rising youngsters like Aakarshi Kashyap and Ayush Shetty. The highest-ranked men's

Bouncing back: After the disappointment of a fourth-place finish at the Paris Olympics, Lakshya Sen won his maiden title at the Syed Modi India International Super 300 tournament with a facile win in the final. SANDEEP SAXENA